

Pregnancy Nutrition Guide

A balanced diet during pregnancy supports the health of both the parent and the developing baby. This guide summarises widely published public-health nutrition advice. It is not a personal medical prescription.

Folic acid is important before conception and in the first twelve weeks because it helps the neural tube close. Many health services recommend a daily folic acid supplement in addition to folate-rich foods such as leafy greens, beans, and fortified cereals.

Iron needs rise in the second half of pregnancy. Iron-rich foods include lean red meat, beans, lentils, and dark green vegetables. Vitamin C from fruit or peppers helps the body absorb plant iron. Tea and coffee taken with meals can reduce absorption.

Hydration matters. Most people feel better if they drink water regularly through the day rather than waiting until they are thirsty. Plain water, milk, and unsweetened drinks are preferred over sugary beverages.

Foods commonly advised against include unpasteurised milk and cheese, raw or undercooked eggs and meat, liver in large amounts, and fish known to be high in mercury such as swordfish. Alcohol is not considered safe at any stage of pregnancy.

This document does not contain medicine dosages. Questions about tablets, pain relief, or supplements other than standard folic acid and vitamin D should be directed to a clinician.